



National  
Qualifications  
2025

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**2025 ESOL**

**Writing**

**Higher**

## **Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions**

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## General marking principles for Higher ESOL Writing

*Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.*

- (a) Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.
- (b) Assessment should be holistic. There may be strengths and weaknesses in the performance; focus as far as possible on the strengths, taking account of weaknesses only where they significantly detract from the overall performance.
- (c) Do not award marks where the candidate has used in their writing chunks of text lifted en bloc from the reading passages.
- (d) Award marks where the candidate demonstrates ability according to the main criteria of content and organisation; vocabulary and spelling; and grammar and punctuation.
- (e) Award the highest level descriptor for writing even if there are a number of basic slips and errors of grammar, spelling and punctuation, etc. These should not detract from your overall impression of the candidate's performance.
- (f) Candidates may display ability across more than one band descriptor. You must consider carefully the most appropriate overall band for the candidate's performance.
- (g) Once the appropriate band descriptor has been selected, follow this guidance
  - if the evidence almost matches the level above, award the highest available mark from the range
  - if the candidate's work just meets the standard described, award the lowest mark from the range
  - otherwise award the mark from the middle of the range
- (h) The script must be legible. Do not make mark judgements based on the quality of the handwriting. If answers are written in capitals, use legibility as a criterion.

|                                 | Description of performance and mark                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |               |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
|                                 | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Work or Study |
|                                 | 15-13                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |               | 12-11                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |               | 10-9                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |               | 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |               |
| <b>Content and organisation</b> | Fully achieves task, using language flexibly and effectively with well-developed support for each point made.<br><br>Writing is coherent and cohesive with a very positive impact on the reader.<br><br>Style and layout are wholly effective in addressing the intended reader. Structure/ paragraphing is consistent and coherent. |               | Fully achieves task, using language effectively with clear support for each point made.<br><br>Writing is coherent and cohesive with a positive impact on the reader.<br><br>Style and layout are wholly appropriate for the intended reader. Structure/ paragraphing is consistent and appropriate. |               | Fully achieves task with clear support for points made.<br><br>Writing is coherent and cohesive and conveys message with ease.<br><br>Style and layout are appropriate for the intended reader.<br><br>The structure is clear and paragraphing follows conventions. |               | Achieves task with clear support for most points made.<br><br>Writing is coherent and cohesive and message is clear.<br><br>Style and layout are appropriate for the intended reader. The structure is clear and the paragraphing mainly follows conventions. |               |
| <b>Vocabulary and spelling</b>  | Uses an optimum range of vocabulary accurately and effectively within the context of the task. Spelling is mainly accurate with very occasional errors.                                                                                                                                                                              |               | Uses a wide range of vocabulary accurately and effectively within the context of the task. Spelling is mainly accurate with occasional errors.                                                                                                                                                       |               | Uses a wide range of vocabulary accurately and appropriately within the context of the task. Spelling is mostly accurate and errors are not persistent.                                                                                                             |               | Uses a sufficiently wide range of vocabulary with a level of accuracy appropriate to the task. Spelling is mostly accurate and any errors do not interfere with intelligibility.                                                                              |               |
| <b>Grammar and punctuation</b>  | Uses an optimum range of grammatical structures effectively, with a high level of accuracy.<br><br>Punctuation is consistently accurate.                                                                                                                                                                                             |               | Uses a wide range of grammatical structures effectively with a high level of accuracy.<br><br>Punctuation is consistent and appropriate.                                                                                                                                                             |               | Uses a wide range of grammatical structures with a reasonable level of accuracy.<br><br>Punctuation is mostly accurate.                                                                                                                                             |               | Uses a sufficiently wide range of grammatical structures, and the message is conveyed with ease despite some errors.<br><br>Punctuation is sufficiently accurate and appropriate to task purpose.                                                             |               |

|                                 | Description of performance and mark                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |               |                                                                                                                                                                            |               |                                                                             |               |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
|                                 | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                                                                                                                              | Work or Study | Everyday life                                                               | Work or Study |
|                                 | 7-6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |               | 5-3                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |               | 2-1                                                                                                                                                                        |               | 0                                                                           |               |
| <b>Content and organisation</b> | Task may be achieved.<br><br>Coherence is weak in places and range of cohesive devices is limited and/or used inappropriately. Message may be difficult to follow.<br><br>Style and layout may be inappropriate for intended reader. There is no evidence of paragraphing and structure may be confused. |               | Writing is mainly irrelevant to task.<br><br>Lack of coherence and cohesion means message is not conveyed on first reading.<br><br>Style and layout may be inappropriate for intended reader. Structure is confused. |               | Writing does not relate to task.<br><br>There is little or no coherence or cohesion.<br><br>Style and layout are inappropriate for intended reader. Structure is confused. |               | No evidence produced by candidate that matches descriptions of performance. |               |
| <b>Vocabulary and spelling</b>  | Uses a limited range of vocabulary with errors in accuracy and appropriateness.<br><br>Persistent spelling errors may interfere with intelligibility.                                                                                                                                                    |               | Only basic vocabulary attempted, with frequent errors.<br><br>Persistent spelling errors impede intelligibility.                                                                                                     |               | Only very basic vocabulary attempted, with very frequent errors.<br><br>Frequent and persistent spelling errors impede intelligibility.                                    |               | No evidence produced by candidate that matches descriptions of performance. |               |
| <b>Grammar and punctuation</b>  | Uses only a limited range of grammatical structures, which may contain frequent errors and interfere with communication. Punctuation may be inaccurate.                                                                                                                                                  |               | Grammatical structures contain frequent errors, which impede communication.<br><br>Punctuation may be inaccurate.                                                                                                    |               | Errors predominate.<br><br>Punctuation is inaccurate.                                                                                                                      |               | No evidence produced by candidate that matches descriptions of performance. |               |

[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]